

AN INVESTMENT READ ON 1,000 BOOTSTRAPPED STARTUPS

Crowded isn't the same as winning

Everyone is piling into AI. The data says the typical AI startup isn't the one making money.

1,000

STARTUPS TRACKED

65

COUNTRIES

\$13.5M

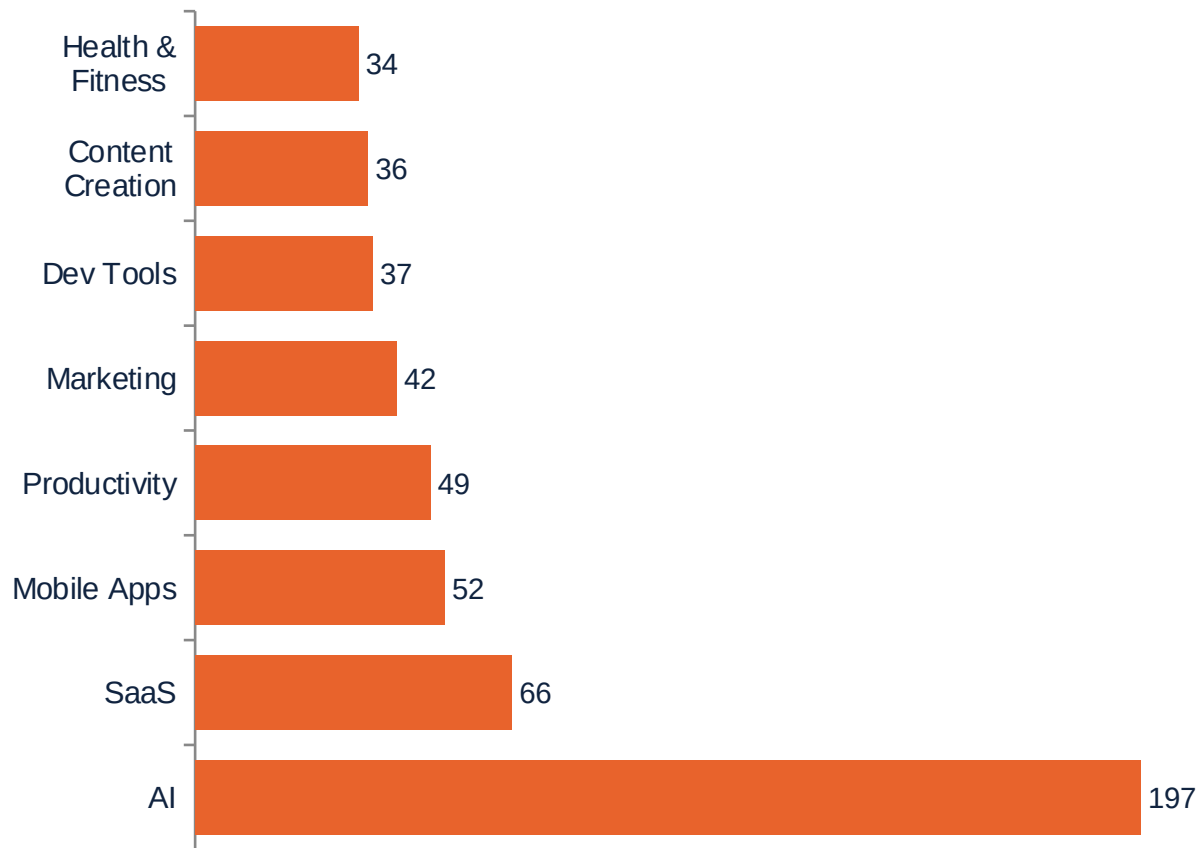
COMBINED MRR

Source: TrustMRR live-revenue dataset, frozen 30 Jul 2026

What we're looking at

1,000 live, revenue-generating startups

Real Stripe / RevenueCat-verified MRR — not self-reported claims, not projections.



65

countries represented

56%

of startups sell direct to consumer

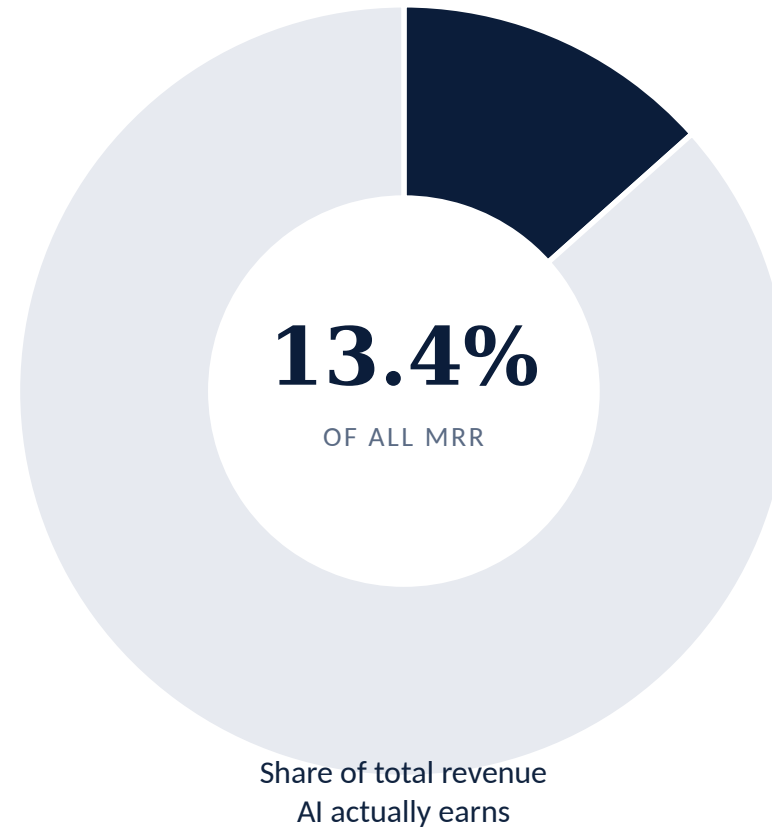
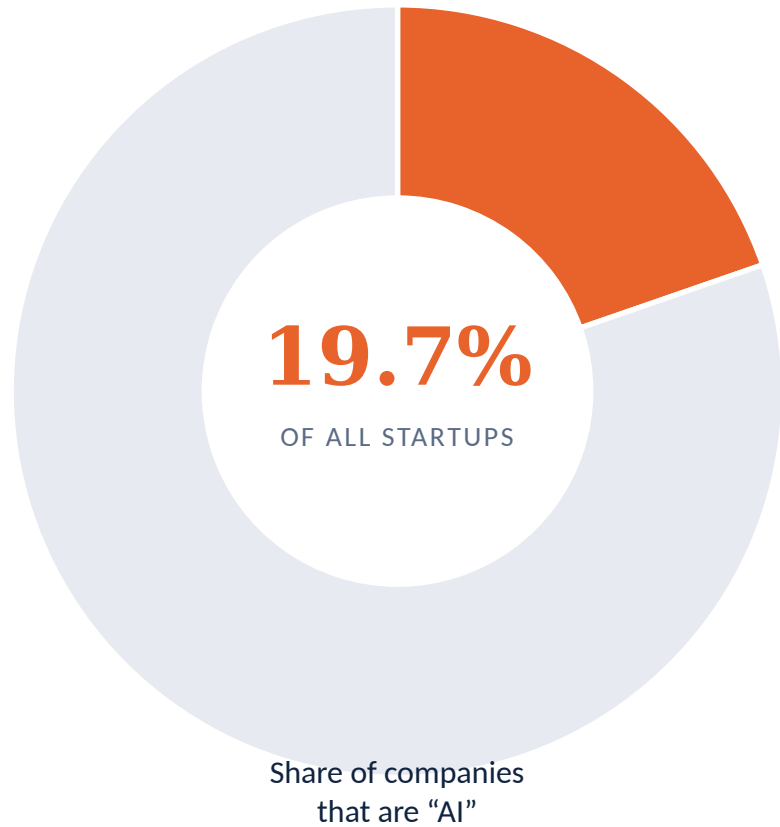
\$13.5M

combined monthly recurring revenue

The gold rush

1 in 5 startups here is an “AI” company

But that crowd doesn’t convert into a proportional share of the money.

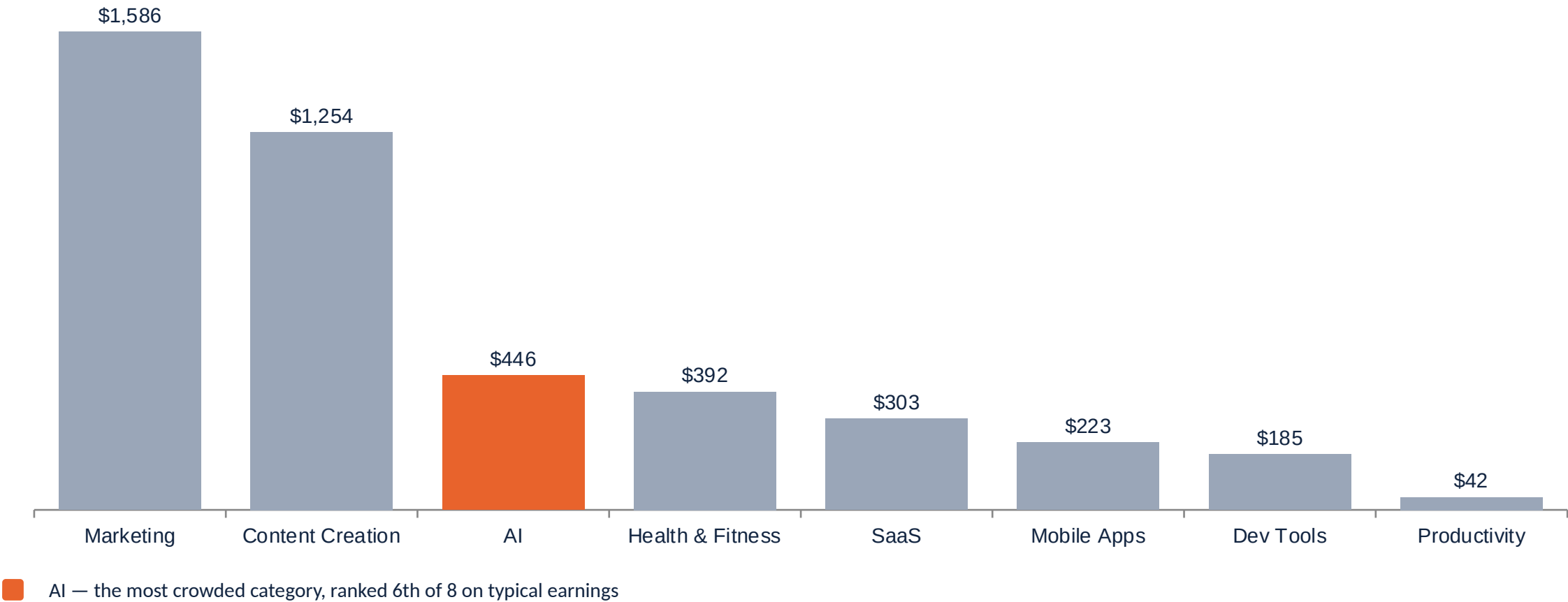


AI attracts nearly 3× the founders of the next largest category, SaaS — for a smaller slice of the revenue pie.

The typical company, not the outliers

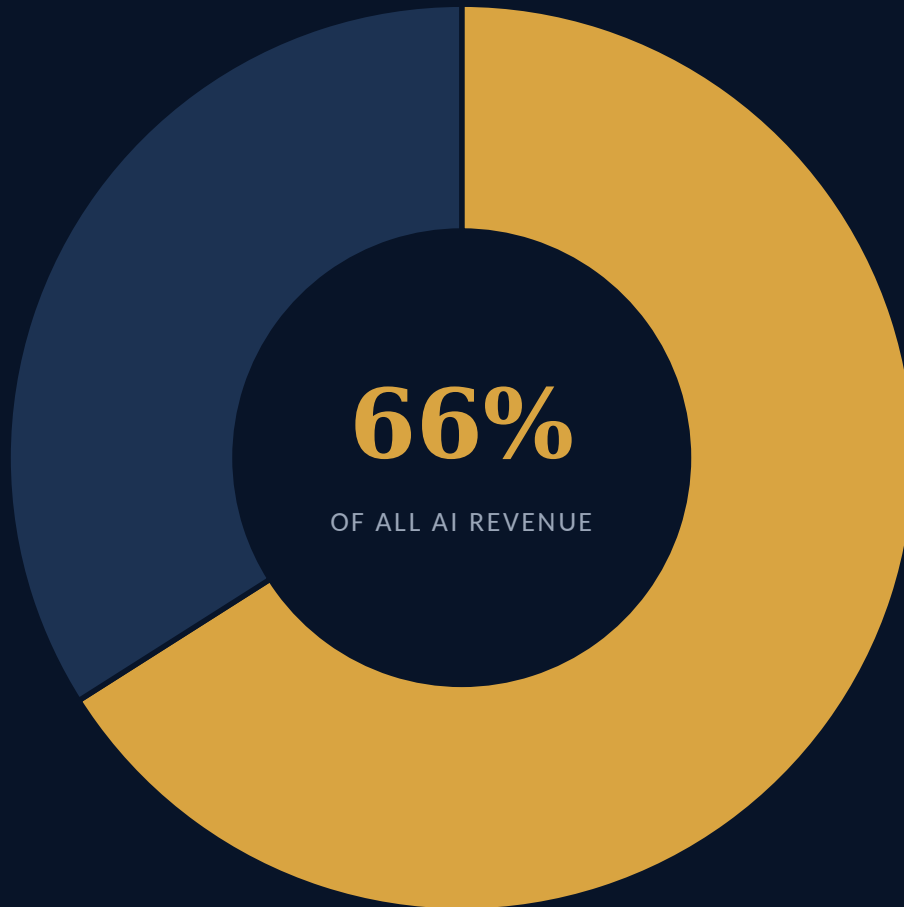
The median AI startup earns less than its peers

Median monthly recurring revenue, by category (top 8 categories by company count)



Inside the AI category

A handful of winners carry the entire category



5%

of AI startups (the top 10 of 197) collect two-thirds of all AI revenue in this dataset.

95%

of AI startups — 187 companies — split the remaining third among themselves.

Backing "AI" as a category is closer to buying a lottery ticket than buying the median outcome.

Hype vs. traction

A big following is a weak signal of revenue

Correlation between X (Twitter) followers and MRR across the dataset: only 0.30

AI — SOCIAL LISTENING TOOL

Stalkr

X FOLLOWERS

362,000

MONTHLY REC. REVENUE

\$0

AI — THE CATEGORY'S TOP EARNER

GojiberryAI

X FOLLOWERS

18,050

MONTHLY REC. REVENUE

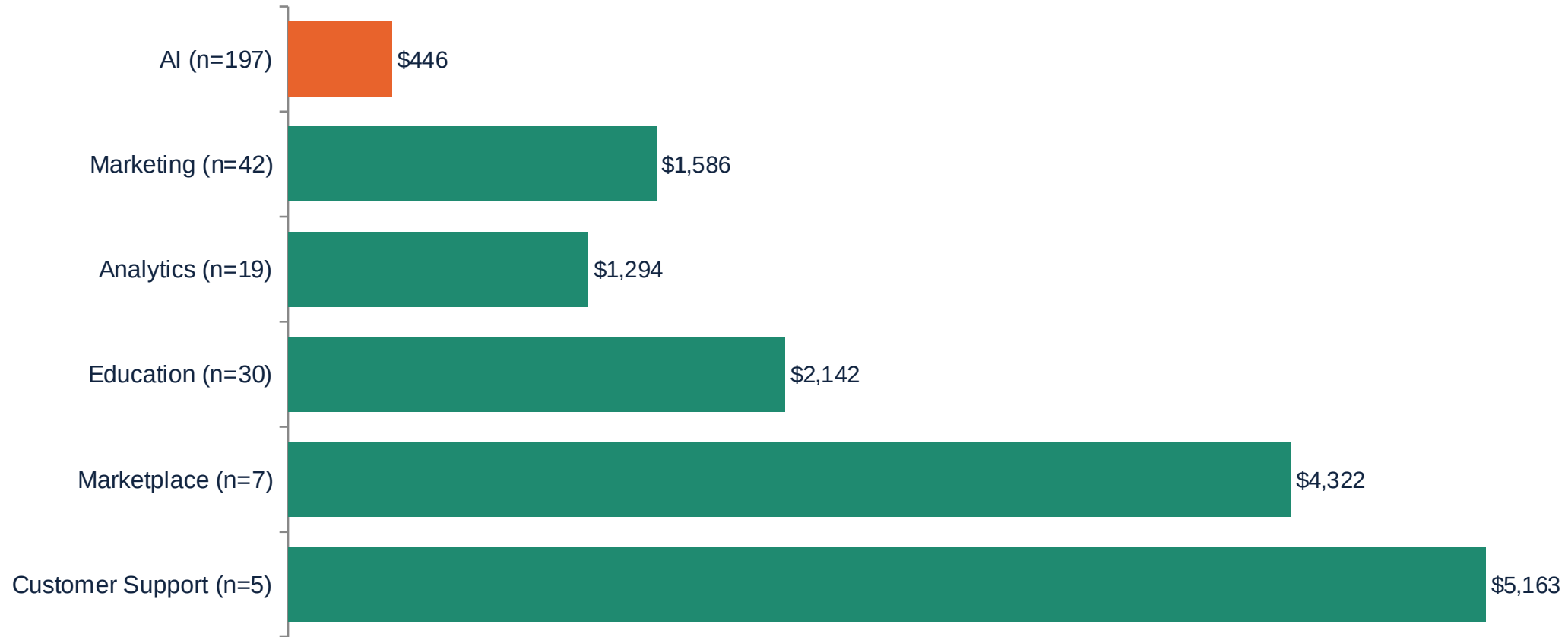
\$494,668

Nearly 20× the audience produced zero revenue — while a much smaller, less-followed account leads the entire AI category.

Away from the crowd

Smaller categories, healthier typical outcomes

Median MRR: less-crowded categories vs. AI



Smaller categories carry far fewer founders chasing the same buyers — and it shows up in the typical company's revenue.

THE TAKE

Don't underwrite the category. Underwrite the company.

01 Category size is a crowding signal, not a quality signal.

AI holds 19.7% of startups but only 13.4% of revenue — the label alone tells you little about the business.

02 Check concentration before you check the pitch.

The top 5% of AI startups here earn two-thirds of the category's revenue — ask where a target really sits in that curve.

03 Score traction, not audience.

Follower count only weakly tracks revenue ($r = 0.30$) — diligence on actual MRR beats diligence on social proof.